

Learning Objective 1.6: I can set up and interpret the radiation integrals to derive the far-field pattern of a current distribution.

Show your work. A **Documentation** line at the end is required (write **None** if you did not collaborate).

1. **Setting up the integral.** Answer each in one or two sentences (or one equation).

- (a) Why do we solve for the magnetic vector potential $\vec{A}$ instead of attacking $\vec{E}$ directly? What property of $\vec{B}$ guarantees $\vec{A}$ exists?

$\vec{E}$ and $\vec{H}$ are coupled and the source enters through a curl. $\vec{A}$ absorbs the source into a single equation ($\nabla^2 \vec{A} + k^2 \vec{A} = -\mu \vec{J}$) whose solution is already known. It exists because $\nabla \cdot \vec{B} = 0$ always, and a divergence-free field is always the curl of something.

- (b) The far field uses *two different* approximations to $R = |\vec{r} - \vec{r}'|$. Write both and state where each is used.

Amplitude: $1/R \approx 1/r$ (a fractional error of order r'/r). Phase: $R \approx r - \hat{r} \cdot \vec{r}'$, because $k\hat{r} \cdot \vec{r}'$ is several radians and controls whether contributions add or cancel.

- (c) Write the far-field vector potential in the form (spherical wave) $\times$ (radiation vector), and say what each factor depends on.

$$\vec{A} = \frac{\mu e^{-jkr}}{4\pi r} \vec{N}(\theta, \phi), \quad \vec{N} = \int_{V'} \vec{J}(\vec{r}') e^{+jk\hat{r} \cdot \vec{r}'} dV'$$

e^{-jkr}/r depends only on *distance* and is the same for every antenna; $\vec{N}$ depends only on *direction* and carries everything that makes this antenna different.

- (d) A $\hat{z}$ -directed current gives $N_\theta = -N_z \sin(\theta)$. Where does that $\sin(\theta)$ come from, and what does it predict about radiation along the wire axis?

It is the *projection* of a $\hat{z}$ -directed current onto $\hat{\theta}$ — not part of the integral. At $\theta = 0^\circ$ the projection vanishes, so a wire antenna radiates nothing off its own ends.

2. **The term we throw away.** A reflector antenna has largest dimension $D = 0.8\text{m}$ and operates at 6GHz. The quadratic term dropped from the expansion of R leaves a worst-case phase error $\Delta\phi = \pi D^2/(4\lambda r)$.

(a) Find λ .

$$\lambda = \frac{c}{f} = \frac{3 \times 10^8}{6 \times 10^9} = 0.05\text{m}$$

$$\lambda = \boxed{0.05\text{m}}$$

(b) A test range puts the source at $r = 20\text{m}$. Find $\Delta\phi$ in degrees.

$$\Delta\phi = \frac{\pi(0.8)^2}{4(0.05)(20)} = \frac{2.011}{4} = 0.503 \text{ rad} \approx 28.8^\circ$$

$$\Delta\phi = \boxed{\approx 28.8^\circ}$$

(c) Find the smallest r for which $\Delta\phi \leq 22.5^\circ$ ($\pi/8$). Compare it to $2D^2/\lambda$.

$$\frac{\pi D^2}{4\lambda r} \leq \frac{\pi}{8} \quad \longrightarrow \quad r \geq \frac{2D^2}{\lambda} = \frac{2(0.8)^2}{0.05} = 25.6\text{m}$$

$$r_{\min} = \boxed{25.6\text{m}}$$

They are the *same* criterion — the far-field distance is exactly the distance at which the parallel-ray approximation becomes honest.

(d) The range in part (b) is too short. Is the measured *pattern* wrong because the amplitude approximation failed, the phase approximation failed, or both?

The **phase** approximation. The $1/R \approx 1/r$ amplitude approximation is still excellent at 20m; it is the leftover 28.8° of quadratic phase across the aperture that distorts the pattern (fills nulls, raises sidelobes).

3. **Uniform line source.** A $\hat{\mathbf{z}}$ -directed filament carries a uniform current I_0 over $-L/2 \leq z' \leq L/2$, with $L = 3\lambda$. Recall the space factor $S(\theta) = |\sin(u)/u|$ with $u = \frac{kL}{2} \cos(\theta)$.

- (a) Evaluate the radiation integral to show where $S(\theta)$ comes from.

$$\begin{aligned} N_z(\theta) &= I_0 \int_{-L/2}^{L/2} e^{+jkz' \cos(\theta)} dz' = I_0 \frac{2 \sin\left(\frac{kL}{2} \cos(\theta)\right)}{k \cos(\theta)} \\ &= I_0 L \frac{\sin(u)}{u}, \quad u = \frac{kL}{2} \cos(\theta) \end{aligned}$$

- (b) Find the angles of the first nulls.

First null at $u = \pi$, i.e. $\cos(\theta) = \lambda/L = 1/3$:

$$\theta = 70.5^\circ \quad \text{and} \quad 109.5^\circ$$

$\theta_{\text{null}} =$

$70.5^\circ, 109.5^\circ$

- (c) Estimate the half-power beamwidth with $0.886\lambda/L$, then check it against the exact half-power condition $u = 1.392$.

Rule of thumb: $0.886/3 = 0.295 \text{ rad} \approx 16.9^\circ$. Exact: $\cos(\theta) = 1.392/(3\pi) = 0.1477 \rightarrow \theta = 81.5^\circ$, so $\text{HPBW} = 2(90^\circ - 81.5^\circ) = 17.0^\circ$. The rule of thumb is good to 0.1° here.

HPBW =

$\approx 17^\circ$

- (d) The design is changed to $L = 6\lambda$. What happens to the beamwidth, and what happens to the first sidelobe level? Justify both from the Fourier relationship.

Beamwidth **halves** to $\approx 8.5^\circ$ — stretching the current distribution squeezes its transform. The first sidelobe **does not move**: it stays at -13.3 dB , because it is set by the *shape* (the abrupt edges of a uniform distribution), not the length. Beamwidth is bought with size; sidelobes are bought with taper.

4. **Steering with a phase slope.** A uniform line source of length $L = 4\lambda$ is fed with a progressive phase so that the pattern peak moves off broadside to $\theta_0 = 60^\circ$. The excitation is $I(z') = I_0 e^{-jkz' \cos(\theta_0)}$.

- (a) Show from the radiation integral that the peak lands at θ_0 .

$$N_z(\theta) = I_0 \int e^{+jkz'(\cos(\theta) - \cos(\theta_0))} dz'$$

The integrand is in phase across the whole aperture — and the sum therefore maximum — when $\cos(\theta) = \cos(\theta_0)$, i.e. $\theta = \theta_0$. A linear phase across the source shifts the transform; it does not reshape it.

- (b) Find the total phase difference (in degrees) between the two ends of the aperture.

$$\Delta\phi = kL \cos(\theta_0) = 2\pi(4)(0.5) = 4\pi \text{ rad} = 720^\circ$$

$$\Delta\phi = 720^\circ \text{ (} 4\pi \text{)}$$

- (c) The steered beamwidth is approximately $0.886\lambda/(L \sin(\theta_0))$. Evaluate it and compare with the broadside value.

Broadside: $0.886/4 = 0.2215 \text{ rad} = 12.7^\circ$. Steered: $12.7^\circ/\sin(60^\circ) = 14.7^\circ$. The beam *broadens* because the aperture looks shorter when viewed from 60° — its projected length is $L \sin(\theta_0)$.

$$\text{HPBW} = \approx 14.7^\circ$$

5. **The half-wave dipole.** The sinusoidal current $I(z') = I_0 \sin\left(k\left(\frac{L}{2} - |z'|\right)\right)$ with $L = \lambda/2$ produces the far-field pattern

$$|F(\theta)| = \left| \frac{\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{2} \cos(\theta)\right)}{\sin(\theta)} \right|$$

- (a) Evaluate $|F|$ at $\theta = 90^\circ$ and at $\theta = 0^\circ$, and interpret each.

At $\theta = 90^\circ$: $\cos(\theta) = 0$, so $|F| = \cos(0)/1 = 1$ — maximum, broadside to the wire. At $\theta = 0^\circ$: numerator $\cos(\pi/2) = 0$ and denominator $\rightarrow 0$; the limit is 0 — a genuine null off the ends of the wire.

- (b) Evaluate $|F|$ at $\theta = 45^\circ$, in dB relative to the peak.

$$\begin{aligned} |F| &= \frac{\cos\left(\frac{\pi}{2}(0.7071)\right)}{0.7071} = \frac{\cos(63.6^\circ)}{0.7071} & |F(45^\circ)| &= \boxed{0.628 \text{ (} -4.0 \text{ dB)}} \\ &= \frac{0.4440}{0.7071} = 0.628 \\ &\rightarrow 20\log_{10}(0.628) \approx -4.0 \text{ dB} \end{aligned}$$

- (c) An infinitesimal dipole has $|F| = \sin(\theta)$, which at 45° is 0.707 (−3.0 dB). The half-wave dipole is 1 dB further down at the same angle. Explain physically why the half-wave pattern is *sharper*, in terms of the current distribution.

The half-wave dipole's current is *tapered* — peaked at the feed and zero at the tips — so the radiating current is concentrated near the middle of a structure that is a half wavelength long, rather than spread uniformly over a vanishingly short one. A longer effective distribution has a narrower transform, so the beam is narrower: HPBW = 78.1° versus 90° , and $D = 1.64$ (2.15 dBi) versus 1.5 (1.76 dBi).

- (d) The radiation integral is exact once $\vec{J}$ is known. State what makes $\vec{J}$ hard to know, and name the numerical method that solves for it.

The current is set by the fields, which are set by the current — a self-consistent (boundary-value) problem. The **method of moments** discretizes the structure, enforces the boundary condition on each segment, and solves a linear system for the segment currents; it then runs this same radiation integral to get the pattern. (This is what NEC does.)

6. **Reading the Fourier relationship.** Four aperture distributions of the *same* length L produce first sidelobes of -13.3 dB , -23 dB , -26.5 dB , and -31.5 dB .

- (a) Match each level to its distribution: uniform, cosine taper, cosine-squared taper, triangular.

uniform $\rightarrow -13.3$ dB , cosine $\rightarrow -23$ dB
triangular $\rightarrow -26.5$ dB , cosine-squared $\rightarrow -31.5$ dB

The smoother the distribution goes to zero at the edges, the less high-space-frequency content it has, and the lower the sidelobes.

- (b) All four have the same L . Rank their half-power beamwidths and explain the trade.

Uniform is *narrowest*, then cosine, then triangular, then cosine-squared (widest). Tapering throws away the outer part of the aperture, so the effective length shrinks and the beam broadens. **Sidelobe level is bought with beamwidth** — the central trade of aperture design (L15, L24).

- (c) Your requirement is a 2° beam with sidelobes below -25 dB . Which knob sets which requirement?

Length sets the beamwidth ($\theta_{\text{HP}} \approx 0.886\lambda/L$, so L of order 25λ), and the **taper shape** sets the sidelobe level (a triangular or cosine-squared illumination). Then iterate: the taper broadens the beam, so the aperture must grow a little to hold 2° .

Documentation: _____